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# Uptake, Implementation, Portability, and Operability of the One Nation One Ration Card: A Study

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## KEY POINTS

- The One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC) scheme allows poor interstate, interdistrict, and intradistrict domestic migrant workers to access subsidized food grain entitlements at any electronic point of sales-enabled fair price shop (FPS) irrespective of place of domicile.
- The Asian Development Bank study entitled "Increasing Uptake of Portability Transactions in ONORC" indicated that
  - majority of migrants were aware of the scheme,
  - many beneficiaries (in particular intra- and interdistrict migrants) were utilizing it,
  - rations available were perceived to be timely and of adequate quality, and
  - the scheme was leading to reduction in food expenses of vulnerable migrant households.
- Improvements could be made through better training of FPS dealers, augmenting FPS stocks to service portable transactions, and providing food grains according to dietary preferences.
- Adoption of ONORC may expand faster with greater awareness, superior technological infrastructure, more efficient supply chain management, and better access for women and other vulnerable groups.

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## INTRODUCTION

India's public distribution system (PDS), launched in 1940s in response to the Bengal famine and later formalized in 1960s, has sustained through the years to address food scarcity challenges in the country.[1] The PDS has undergone several modifications to better target physically remote or economically weaker populations. The system was revamped in 1992 to reach subsidized food grains to inaccessible areas inhabited by tribal, marginalized, vulnerable, or poor populations. The targeted public distribution system (TPDS) was envisaged in 1997 to deliver PDS benefits to households living below the poverty line (BPL). In 2000, Antyodaya Anna Yojana was introduced to cover the poorest segments of the BPL population. It went through multiple revisions, expanding its coverage to households headed by widows, terminally ill persons and people with disabilities, low wage labor including landless agricultural workers, marginal farmers, rural artisans, primitive tribal households, etc.

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[1] The Bengal famine of 1943 (in British India) resulted in about 3 million fatalities owing to malnutrition and disease; Encyclopaedia Britannica. 2022. Bengal famine of 1943. 9 June. https://www.britannica.com/topic/Bengal-famine-of-1943.

Further, the National Food Security Act (NFSA) enacted in 2013 stipulated that 75% of the rural and 50% of the urban population would receive subsidized food grains through TPDS. Based on the Census of India 2011,[2] All India Poverty Lines 2011–12,[3] and the Monthly Household Consumer Expenditure Survey 2011–12,[4] population entitled to food grains under NFSA in each state or union territory was defined.

For better effectiveness and cost-optimization, end-to-end computerization of TPDS operations program was initiated in 2012. Also, in April 2018, the Integrated Management of Public Distribution System scheme of the Department of Food and Public Distribution (DFPD), Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food and Public Distribution, Government of India was operationalized across all states and union territories along with Aadhaar seeding of ration cards, integration of electronic point of sale (ePOS) with weighing scales, etc., bringing significant efficiency to the system. The creation of a central repository of all NFSA ration cards paved the way for beneficiaries to receive their food grain entitlement at any fair price shop (FPS) across the country. They only needed to present their ration card details for the FPS to release the rations using ePOS machines and verifying the transaction through biometric authentication.

In its initial design, PDS could only deliver rations at the place of domicile where the beneficiaries were registered, that is, the FPS near the BPL homestead (home FPS). However, starting early 1990s, as the Indian economy liberalized, it became more urban-centric and more jobs shifted to urban areas. Today, an estimated 454 million Indians live at a location different from their place of domicile.[5] Although the majority of this migration is on account of marriage, when the Indian woman traditionally moves into her marital home, significant internal migration is also in search of remunerative economic activity. Though the rate of migration has slowed down in recent years, it continues to present the challenge of delivering food grains to the migrant workers at their place of migration (destination), while their families are catered to by the home FPS.

The DFPD launched the One Nation One Ration Card (ONORC) scheme for nationwide portability of ration cards under NFSA 2013, allowing eligible cardholders to access food grains from any ePOS-enabled FPS across the country. Initially piloted in four states in 2019,[6] the scheme gained importance during the coronavirus disease (COVID-19) pandemic, due to its potential to empower those who had lost their livelihoods and were forced to return to their native places. As part of its COVID-19 economic relief package, the government announced the nationwide rollout of ONORC by March 2021 as part of the technology-driven system reforms under the AatmaNirbhar Bharat Abhiyan (or the self-reliant India campaign) unveiled by the Prime Minister of India. On 29 June 2021, the Supreme Court of India also issued directives to the central and state governments to implement the ONORC scheme by 31 July 2021. By 31 August 2021, the scheme had been successfully deployed in most states and Union Territories barring Assam and Chhattisgarh. With the intra- and interstate portability of transactions enabled by the scheme, more than 300 million such transactions were recorded between April 2020 and July 2021.[7] Monthly interstate transactions rose more than 38 times from 21,000 in April 2020 to reach 813,000 in December 2021 (Figure 1). Intradistrict transactions dominated with more than 130 million recorded in 2021.

## DATA

In April 2020, under its COVID-19 Active Response and Expenditure Support (CARES) program, the Asian Development Bank (ADB) extended $1.5 billion in assistance to the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Yojana (PMGKY), Government of India's $23 billion pro-poor scheme.[8] For the pandemic period, the PMGKY enabled free food and cooking gas distribution to low-income and vulnerable populations, including women. A technical assistance (TA) attached to the CARES loan was also extended to develop the operational framework and strengthen the efficiency in targeting, delivery, and monitoring and evaluation of select PMGKY schemes, including ONORC, for not just existing but also new pandemic-affected beneficiaries.[9]

2 Government of India, Ministry of Home Affairs, Office of the Registrar General and Census Commissioner of India. 2011. *Census of India 2011*. https://censusindia.gov.in/census.website/.

3 Government of India, Planning Commission. 2013. *Press Note on Poverty Estimates, 2011-12*. https://niti.gov.in/sites/default/files/2020-05/press-note-poverty-2011-12-23-08-16.pdf.

4 Government of India, Ministry of Statistics & Programme Implementation. 2012. Household Consumer Expenditure, Type 1: July 2011 - June 2012, National Sample Survey 68th Round. http://microdata.gov.in/nada43/index.php/catalog/1/download/1309.

5 R. Kundu. 2018 . A Study On Internal Migration In India. *International Journal of Creative Research Thoughts*. Volume 6, Issue 1. March. https://ijcrt.org/papers/IJCRT1872369.pdf

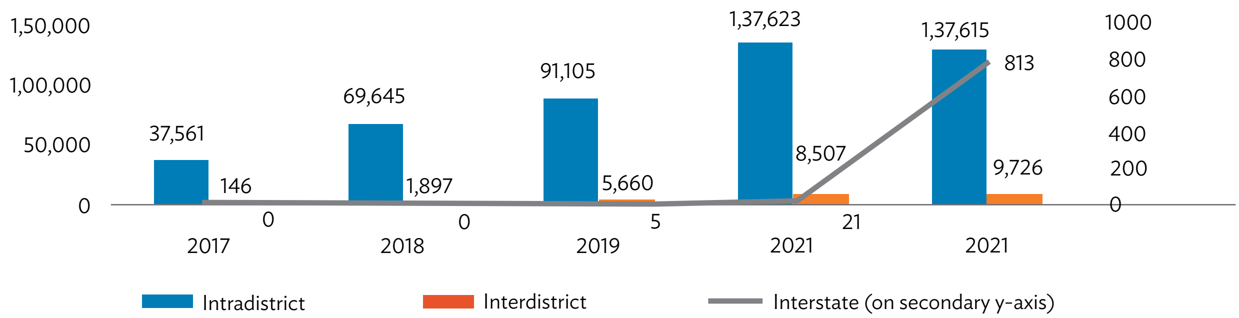
6 Two clusters, namely, Andhra Pradesh, and Telangana (Cluster-1) and Maharashtra and Gujarat (Cluster-2).

7 Government of India, Ministry of Consumer Affairs, Food & Public Distribution, 2021. https://pib.gov.in/PressReleasePage.aspx?PRID=1749917.

8 ADB. 2020. Report and Recommendation of the President to the Board of Directors: Proposed Countercyclical Support Facility Loans and Technical Assistance Grant to India for the COVID-19 Active Response and Expenditure Support Program. Manila.

9 ADB. 2020. TA 9969-IND: Building Capacity for Improved Implementation of Government's COVID-19 Response and Pro-Poor Economic Package. Manila. The TA aimed to (i) recommend future scheme design for economic restoration; (ii) identify affected people not covered in any of the sub-schemes (e.g., migrant workers); (iii) provide better incentives for certain subcategories of people such as construction workers, health workers, and women; and (iv) share good practices for economic stimulus and health sector-strengthening interventions from other countries.

**Figure 1: Monthly Portable Transactions under One Nation One Ration Card Scheme, 2017–2021 ('000 transactions)**




*Sources:*
(i) Integrated Management of Public Distribution System portal. https://impds.nic.in/portal.
(ii) Annavitran portal. https://annavitran.nic.in/AVL/welcome.
(iii) ADB study team analysis.

On the request of the DFPD, a study entitled "Increasing Uptake of Portability Transactions in One Nation One Ration Card" was conducted under the TA. As part of the study, quantitative migrant and nonmigrant surveys were conducted covering two districts each in four key migration-linked states.[10] The primary survey covered 1,311 migrants, 450 nonmigrants, 16 focus group discussions (FGDs) with migrants, 166 FPSs, and more than 50 government and other relevant stakeholders. In line with the observation that rations are mostly procured by women, 64% migrant and 77% nonmigrant survey respondents were women. All respondents were above 18, mostly between 30 and 45 years of age. All social categories were well represented, with 32% respondents belonging to Scheduled Castes, 31% to Backward Castes, 11% to Scheduled Tribes, and 24% to the general category.

## FINDINGS

### Beneficiary Demographics

**Employment.** Only 13% of the migrant respondents and 14% of the nonmigrants reported that they were employed full-time. More than 50% migrants were part-time employees and 6% unemployed. Since the survey had a high representation of women, 27% of the migrant respondents and 50% of the nonmigrants were homemakers. Of the migrant respondents, 32% reported being "other casual labor" while 18% each reported to be in industrial and construction work.

**Income and landownership.** Of the respondent households, in only 4% were more than half the members earning; 23% reported 25%–50% members to be earning, and 73% reported less than 25% earning members. Income levels of migrant respondents were found to be lower than that of nonmigrants as the monthly household income of 64% migrant and 59% nonmigrant respondents fell in the range of ₹5,000–₹10,000. Of the respondents, 17% migrant and 15% nonmigrant families reported a monthly household income of less than ₹5,000. About 5% nonmigrant families reported a monthly household income of more than ₹20,000, while migrant respondent households in this income category were less than 1%. Agricultural land was owned by 10% migrant and 5% nonmigrant respondent households; homestead land was reported to be owned by 8% migrant and 10% nonmigrant families. In total, 17% migrant and 14% nonmigrant families owned land—agricultural, homestead, or both.

**Other government benefits.** Of the respondents, 17% had secured free elementary education, 14% reported access to anganwadi centers (early childhood care centers under Integrated Child Development Services), and 13% were using subsidized cooking gas cylinders under the Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana. About half the respondent households had not availed themselves of any government benefit.[11]

**Digital literacy.** Of the nonmigrant respondents, 63% and of the migrants, 56% owned smartphones. Among those who did not own one, 3% of nonmigrants and 5% of migrants knew how to

[10] Patna and Muzaffarpur in Bihar; North-West and South districts in Delhi; Mumbai Suburb and Pune in Maharashtra; and Chennai and Coimbatore in Tamil Nadu.
[11] Survey questionnaire inquired about other government benefits such as anganwadi center benefits related to health, food, and education; Mahatma Gandhi National Rural Employment Guarantee; widow pension; old age pension; free elementary education (I to VIII standard); Pradhan Mantri Krishi Sammaan Yojana; Pradhan Mantri Ujjwala Yojana; Pradhan Mantri Shram Yogi Maan Dhan Yojana; direct benefit transfer (DBT) for ration under PDS; and any other scheme.

operate them. Smartphone ownership was 62% among men and 55% among women. More nonmigrants than migrants and more men than women were digitally literate. Smartphone usage by beneficiaries was assessed for four common purposes, viz., social media, WhatsApp, downloading of apps, and web surfing. Among these, WhatsApp usage was highest at 59%, closely followed by web surfing, downloading of apps, and social media usage. Of the beneficiaries, 41% used smartphones for all the four purposes. Mobile banking services were used by 26% beneficiaries, while 20% used their smartphones for paying bills online. Only 13% of beneficiaries had registered for government schemes through smartphones.

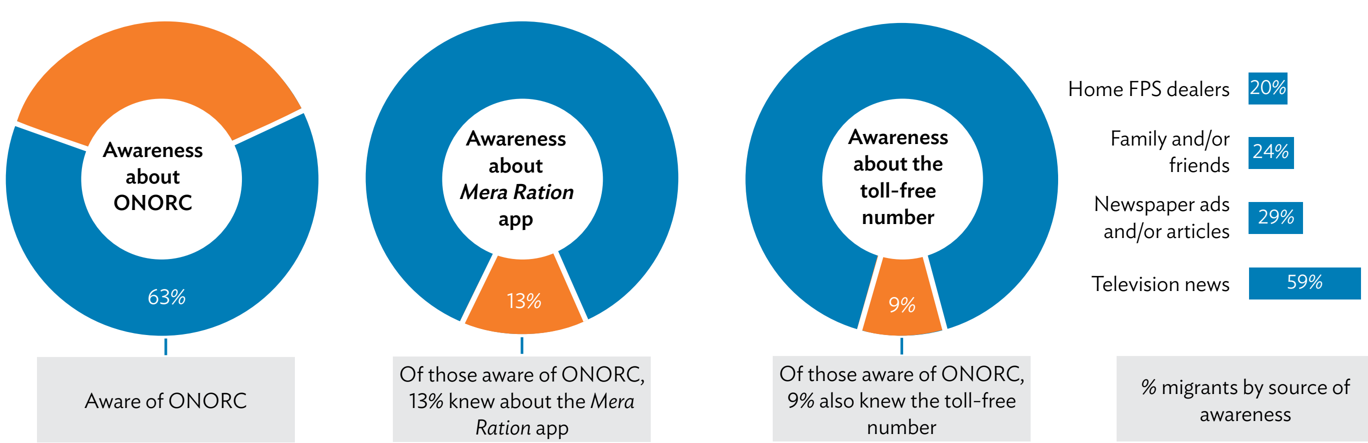
**Migration.** Search for employment was the primary reason for migration reported by 78% of migrant respondents with 12% having migrated for education and 10% post-marriage. Of the migrants, 55% migrated for more than 12 months at a single stretch, while another 20% migrated for less than 6 months. Intrastate, interdistrict, and intradistrict migration patterns were more or less similar with "duration" being the key differentiator—only 9% interstate migrants moved out for "less than 6 months." Since interstate migration is expensive, such migrants obviously try to live and earn longer at the destination. Of the households that migrated, 47% moved with more than 75% of the family members; 8% moved with less than 25% of the family members. In 11% migrant respondent families, only the male members migrated, leaving the women and girls at the native place. This pattern was more common among interstate migrant households (reported by 21% families). Of the respondent migrant households with women members at the destination, 58% reported that the women too had moved in search of work while the rest said that they had moved to accompany their men.

**Impact of the pandemic on migration.** Though the COVID-19 pandemic and related lockdowns led to widespread reverse migration, especially from major urban centers, once the pandemic abated, only 3% respondent migrant households (overall) reported a reduction in the number of migrants in their families. Among interstate migrants however, the change was more palpable with 6% households reporting such reduction. A distinction may be drawn here between the survey respondents and the FGDs where considerable greater reduction among interstate migrants was said to have been observed. This is perhaps because the survey was restricted to the number reported by the respondent families while during FGDs they shared observations about their friends and acquaintances as well. Employment loss, health concerns, and rising uncertainties were cited as key causes. A significant proportion of the migrant population perceived health services to be inaccessible or unaffordable at the destination. Often, the older persons and the children stayed back while the able-bodied adults migrated in search of work as usual. Long-term employees with job security returned more readily while many in short-term work arrangements lost out. Those who chose not to return either engaged in agricultural activities or started small businesses at the native place.

## Beneficiary Responses

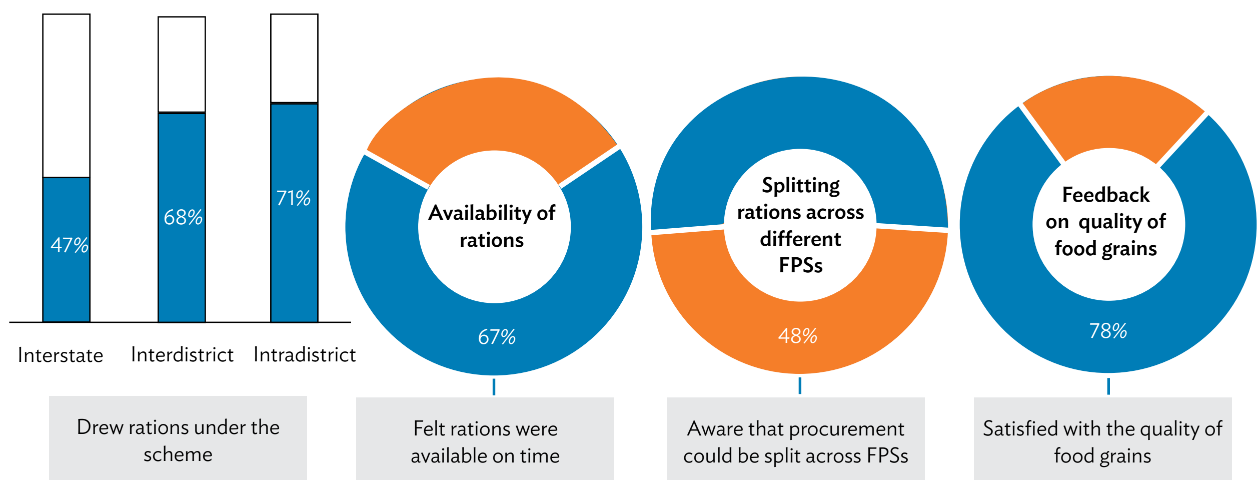
**Status of Aadhaar seeding.** Of the respondents, 94% reported that their ration cards had been seeded with Aadhaar card, of which, 96% were satisfied with the seeding process. Also, 66% stated that their ration cards were linked to their mobile numbers.

Figure 2: Awareness about the One Nation One Ration Card Scheme among Migrant Respondents




Ads = advertisements, App = application, FPS = fair price shop, ONORC = One Nation One Ration Card.
Source: Study team analysis.

Figure 3: Perceptions of Migrant Respondents about the Availability and Quality of Rations




FPS = fair price shop.
Source: Study team analysis.

**Awareness about the scheme.** Most nonmigrant (57%) and migrant (63%) respondents were aware of the ONORC with greater awareness at higher levels of education. The key sources of information were television news and newspaper advertisements. However, awareness regarding Mera Ration app was observed to be low (Figure 2).

**Drawal of rations under the scheme.** Of those aware of the scheme, 71% (of 384) intradistrict, 68% (of 223) interdistrict and 47% (of 219) interstate migrant respondents had drawn rations under the scheme (Figure 3). Though the duration of migration was found to have no impact on the decision to draw rations under ONORC, the presence of women members at the place of migration did increase uptake. Of the migrant households with women members, 66% procured food grains under ONORC as compared to 40% of families comprising only male migrants.

**Perceptions about availability and quality.** Most migrant (67%) and nonmigrant (72%) respondents agreed that the food grains were available on time. Of all the respondents, 78% migrants and 77% nonmigrants also felt that the rations were of satisfactory quality.

**Utilization of the option of splitting ration across different fair price shops.** The option of splitting ration entitlement and drawing rations from different FPSs is useful for families in which only few family members migrate. Among migrants who drew rations under ONORC, 48% were aware of this facility, and 42% of those who were aware had utilized it. As compared to the men, 8% more female migrants were found to be aware of the option of splitting ration.

**Feedback on fair price shop dealers.** While only 19% migrant respondents reported having women FPS dealers, 84% of these respondents were satisfied with their services. In contrast, only 68% migrant respondents using the services of male FPS dealers were satisfied with them.

**Comparison of home with destination fair price shop.** Intra- and interdistrict migrant respondents found no difference between home and destination FPS in terms of performance. Only some interstate migrant respondents reported that their home FPS was better than the destination FPS in terms of quantity (14%), quality (29%), types of food grains (19%), and price (21%).

**Authentication of transactions at fair price shops.** Nearly all (97%) migrant respondents who had drawn rations under ONORC reported transaction verification through fingerprint authentication. Only 3% reported other authentication mechanisms such as iris scan or one-time password on registered mobile number. Though 21% migrant and 31% nonmigrant respondents reported denial of rations due to authentication failure, none of the five major technical issues faced at the FPS—network connectivity, delay in authentication, authentication failure, mismatch in ration card details, and ePOS not fetching ration card details—returned a criticality score of 3 or more (Figure 4).

**Gender-specific issues faced at fair price shops.** Of the respondents, 51% migrant and 42% nonmigrant beneficiaries reported that women faced gender-based issues in drawing rations from the FPS. Factors putting women at a disadvantage in transacting at the FPS (listed by migrant respondents) were

Figure 4: Technical Issues at Fair Price Shops

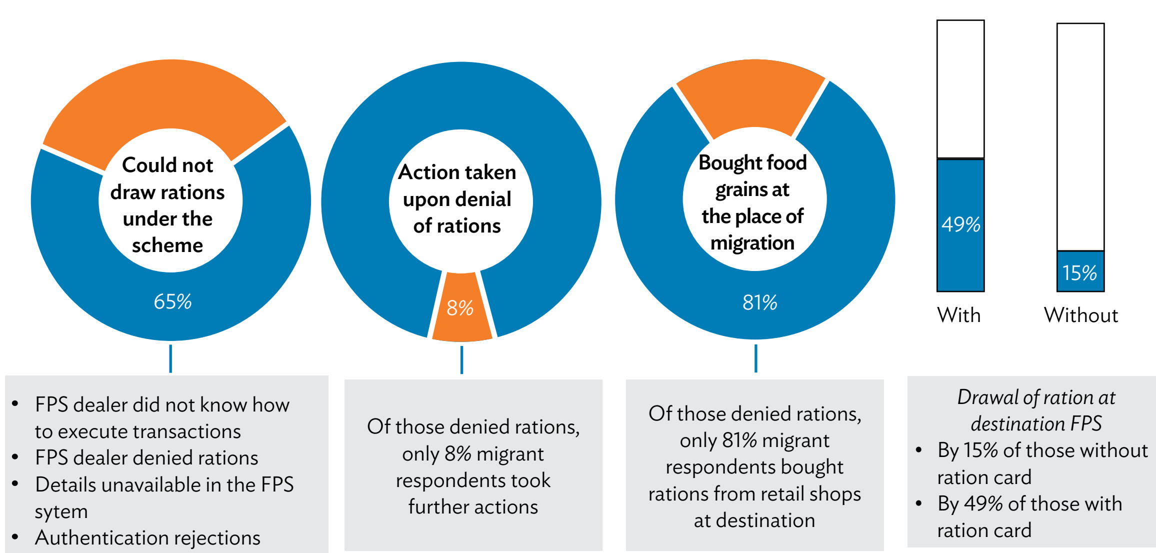

ePOS = electronic point of sale.
Source: Study team analysis.

pressure of household chores (53%), household restrictions (24%), physical possession of ration card by male family member (11%), exploitative malpractices of the FPS dealer (10%), and nonlinking of their Aadhaar with the ration card (1%).

**Reasons for not drawing rations under the scheme.** Among migrant respondents not drawing rations under ONORC, 65% mentioned circumstances such as lack of awareness around portable transactions, unavailability of ration card details in the system, lack of stock, denial of rations by FPS dealer (without citing reason), and repeated authentication issues (Figure 5). The remaining who did not avail of rations despite knowing about the scheme, cited personal reasons such as non-seeding of Aadhaar card, nonmigrating family members withdrawing complete rations (17%), provision of food by employer or contractor at destination (12%), unavailability of physical ration cards, or perceived low grade of food grains.

**Action taken in case of denial of rations.** Of the migrant respondents who did not draw rations under ONORC due to issues beyond their control, only 8% took further action, in terms of registering complaints with concerned government officials or PDS portals of the home state or destination state. Of those who registered complaints, only 31% got their issues resolved.

Figure 5: Migrant Respondents Not Drawing Rations under the Scheme

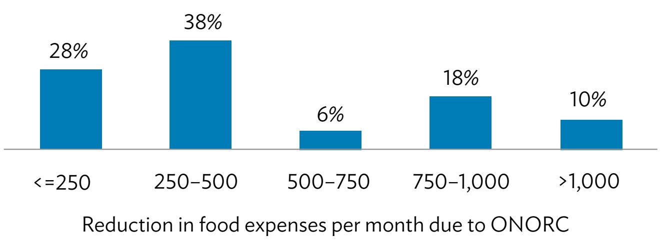



FPS = fair price shop.
Source: Study team analysis

**Source of food grains at the place of migration.** Of the migrants who did not procure food grains under ONORC (irrespective of awareness status about the scheme), 81% got their ration from retail shops. Only 8% of such migrants were provided food by their employers or contractors. Other sources of food and food grains included private and community kitchens.

**Perceived importance of carrying physical ration card to the place of migration.** As shown in Figure 5, only 15% of migrant respondents who did not have their ration cards at the destination procured rations there under the ONORC. This indicates that many thought that presenting the physical card was mandatory for drawing rations at the place of migration.

Figure 6: Distribution of Migrant Respondents Reporting Reduction in Food Expenses (₹)




ONORC = One Nation One Ration Card.
Source: Study team analysis.

**Benefits reported.** Of migrant respondents, 86% stated that the ONORC was a beneficial scheme. Of these, 75% stated that the scheme had helped them in reducing food expenses (amounting to ₹574 per month on average) (Figure 6). Other reported benefits of the ONORC were food security in times of financial crisis (35%), increased access to food (29%), and zero hassle in applying for a new ration card at the place of migration (35%).

**Areas of improvement.** Respondents suggested certain improvements in the scheme such as greater capacity building of FPS dealers regarding their role in the implementation of the ONORC (76%), providing sufficient stock to FPSs for portable transactions (50%), and providing food grains according to dietary preference (42%).

## Profile of Fair Price Shops

**Dealer demographics.** Of the FPS dealers surveyed, nearly all had had some education—Class V (4%), Class IX (14%), Class X (34%), Class XII (22%), graduation (21%), and post graduation (4%). Majority (59%) fell in the 35–54 years age bracket (with 32% being 35–44 years and 27% being 45–54 years old); 19% were more than 55 years old. Of the FPS dealers surveyed, 75% were men.

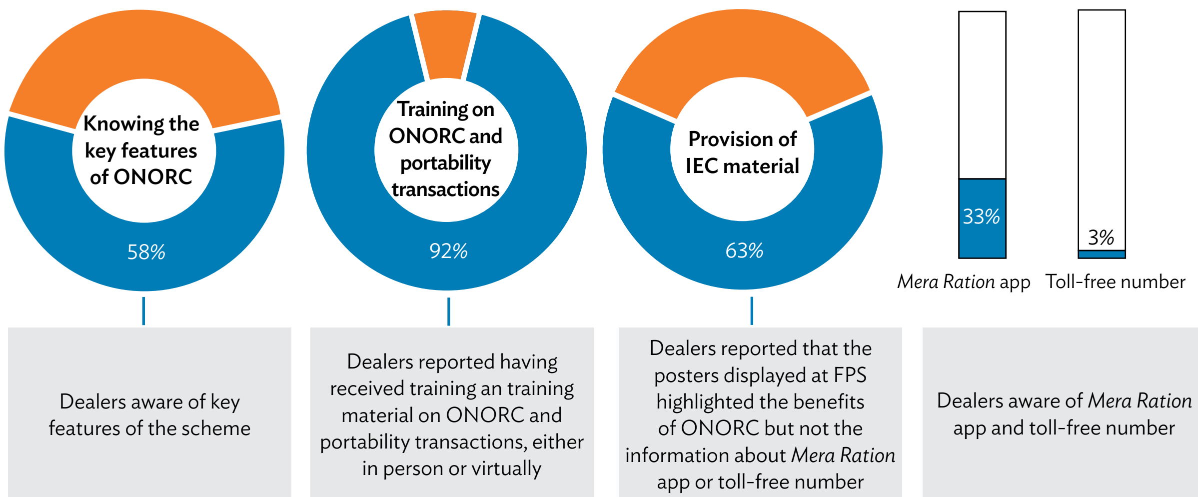
**Types of fair price shops.** Of the FPSs surveyed, 63% were reported to be individually owned, 28% cooperative owned; the rest were owned by self-help groups, government or nongovernment organizations, *gram panchayats* (village-level local bodies), or on partnership-basis. It was observed that in Delhi and Bihar, majority of the FPSs were run by individuals while in Maharashtra, most rural FPSs were run by gram panchayats followed by self-help groups. In Tamil Nadu, on the other hand, most FPSs were run by cooperatives. The premises of 62% FPSs surveyed were owned, while the remaining were rented. Of the premises that were owned, only 72% were reported to be the licensed to the operator. Of the surveyed dealers, 23% conveyed the need for additional storage space for monthly rations.

**Other businesses.** While most FPSs surveyed (69%) handled only PDS commodities such as rice, wheat, sugar, etc., 31% also sold routine grocery items like salt and soap alongside, thus improving product access for the consumer as well as supplementing dealer incomes. Many state governments actively encourage FPS dealers to sell other essentials besides PDS commodities.[12]

**Infrastructure at the fair price shop.** All the surveyed dealers reported necessary infrastructure—including stable electricity connection, electronic weighing machines, and information boards—as available and operational at the FPS. Due to the introduction of ePOS and digitalization of the PDS operations, calculators, manual receipts, and sales registers have become redundant. Nevertheless, they are still available at some FPSs and occasionally used for record maintenance. Electronic weighing scales have replaced traditional ones; stable internet connections, ePOS machines, and fingerprint readers are available. Although an iris scanner is mandatory at the FPS as an alternate mode of authentication, only 49% of the FPS dealers reported the availability of operational iris scanners. Dealers mentioned that computers were not needed at the FPSs as all operations could be performed through the ePOS machines. The dealers also reported that digital payments were yet to be enabled at FPSs.

12 A. Botekar. 2016. Ration shops to sell regular grocery products as well. *The Times of India*. 23 October. https://timesofindia.indiatimes.com/city/nashik/ration-shops-to-sell-regular-grocery-products-as-well/articleshow/55009019.cms; and R Kirubakaran. 2022. PDS shops in Tamil Nadu to sell branded grocery, get design upgrade. 7 July. https://www.newindianexpress.com/states/tamil-nadu/2022/jul/07/pds-shops-in-tamil-nadu-to-sell-branded-grocery-get-design-upgrade-2473783.html.

Figure 7: Training and Awareness of Fair Price Shop Dealers about the Scheme



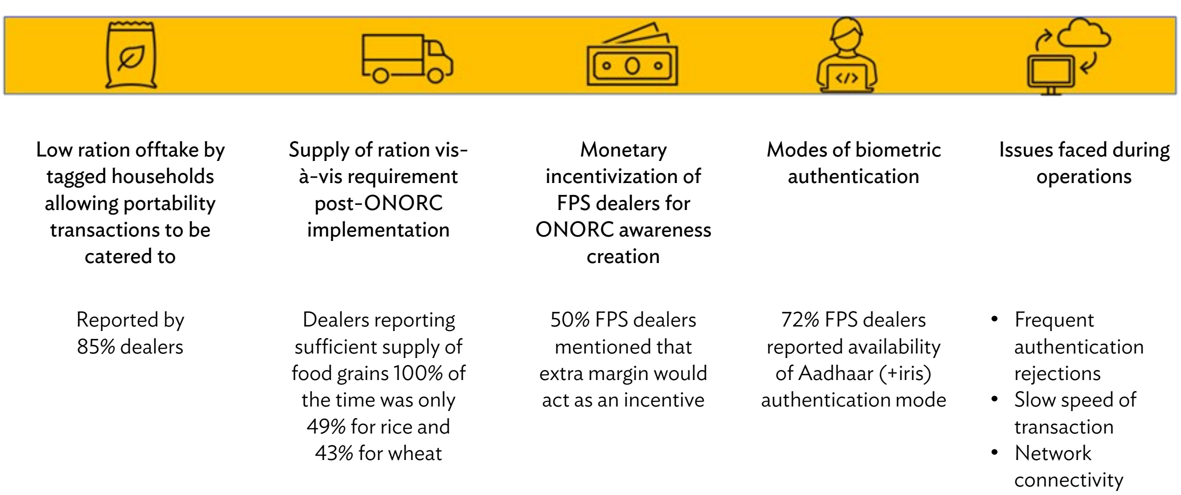

FPS = fair price shop; IEC = Information, education, and communication; ONORC = One Nation One Ration Card.
Source: Study team analysis.

**Information displayed.** Opening and closing hours of the FPS, issue price of food grains, days of closure of FPS, stock of food grains, and dealer information were the most widely displayed across FPSs.

## Dealers' Responses

**Dealer training.** Of the FPS dealers surveyed, 92% reported having received training and training material on ONORC and portable transactions, either in person or virtually, during the COVID-19 pandemic (Figure 7). More in-person trainings were organized for FPS dealers in rural areas (86%) compared to urban areas (51%). Since urban areas have better internet connectivity, the number of virtual trainings for FPS dealers in urban areas was higher (45%) compared to rural areas (4%). Around 80% of the FPS dealers were satisfied with the trainings conducted by the government and comfortable carrying out portable transactions. Those who had received physical training on ONORC were more comfortable with portable transactions than those who had received nonphysical trainings.

Figure 8: Operational Issues Reported by Dealers Regarding Commodity Supply and Biometric Authentication




FPS = fair price shop, ONORC = One Nation One Ration Card.
Source: Study team analysis.

**Awareness about the scheme.** Despite training, only 58% were aware of the four key features of the scheme, that (i) rations can be accessed from any FPS across the country, (ii) a new ration card is not needed under ONORC, (iii) there is no mandate to register separately for ONORC, and (iv) the beneficiary does not need to carry the physical ration card to access rations.

**Operations under the scheme.** As overall ration offtake was less than 100%, about 85% of FPS dealers used regular allocation quantity for portable transactions and ration distribution to migrants. Half the FPS dealers also indicated that extra margins (if offered) could act as potential incentive for them to disseminate awareness about ONORC among beneficiaries (Figure 8).

**Composition of portable transactions.** Dealers reported that interdistrict migrants accounted for 34% of transactions in a month while intradistrict migrants accounted for 56%. Interstate transactions recorded the lowest share. Furthermore, 64% of the FPS dealers reported the need for extra ration allocations to fulfill portable transactions.

**Adequacy of stocks.** Of the FPS dealers surveyed a large proportion (86% in case of rice and 87% for wheat) reported receiving adequate food grains allocation either "always" or "most of the time." Among those reporting routine shortfall, the key reason cited was that the government allocates PDS supplies based on the number of ration cards tagged to an FPS without accounting for the additional demand likely to be generated by portable transactions.

**Awareness about migration in the catchment area.** Of the surveyed dealers, 97% reported awareness about immigration in their catchment area—95% reported the presence of intradistrict, 91% interdistrict, and 74% interstate migrants in their catchment.

**Awareness about ONORC beneficiary registration process, *Mera Ration* app, and toll-free number.** Awareness about the ONORC beneficiary registration process (16%), Mera Ration app (33%), and toll-free number (3%) was low among FPS dealers.

**FPS dealers' feedback on ONORC implementation.** Overall, 75% of the FPS dealers mentioned satisfaction with the implementation of the ONORC scheme while 23% were neutral.

## CONCLUSIONS AND RECOMMENDATIONS

The study highlights the effectiveness of ONORC in enhancing food security for migrant households by improving food grain accessibility and affordability at their destination. It also simplifies the process of obtaining a new ration card at the place of migration. However, it emphasizes the lack of awareness among beneficiaries about various aspects of the ONORC scheme, including the absence of information regarding Aadhaar seeding status, reasons for application delays or rejections, and the mechanism for redressing grievance if ration is denied.

Some migrants perceive that a physical ration card is necessary to avail themselves of rations, while language barriers discourage them from approaching FPS dealers. Additionally, FPS owners have limited awareness about the key features of ONORC, the beneficiary registration process, the utilization of the Mera Ration app, and the toll-free number for ONORC. Their knowledge is also limited in terms of checking ration allocations, portability transactions, ePOS details, and addressing various queries from migrants.

The study also points out technological and supply chain challenges that hinder efficient implementation of the scheme. Regarding technological aspects, the study demonstrates the difficulties that interstate migrants could face in accessing rations at destination states if their ration cards are not linked to Aadhaar. Slow internet connections at FPSs, sluggish speed of portability transactions, and technical glitches resulting in incomplete details on ePOS machines, error messages, rejections in authentication or transactions, and the need for multiple authentication attempts contribute to challenges in the system. Moreover, there are several supply chain challenges identified, such as a shortage of rations at FPSs, a lack of clarity among FPS dealers regarding consumption, absence of real-time or periodic assessment of migration status, distribution cycle variations among different states, and inconsistencies in the supply of rations to FPSs.

To promote the wider adoption of ONORC, the study recommends the implementation of strategies aimed at improving awareness, enhancing technological infrastructure, streamlining the supply chain management, and ensuring better access to the scheme for women and other vulnerable groups.

### Awareness Generation

- Using **social media and public transportation** as well as the influence of **social workers, activists, and local administration staff**, enrollment to the scheme and awareness regarding the schedule could both be enhanced.
- Special drives and capacity-building initiatives could ride on mass events such as **local fairs** and **festivals**, creating marketing platforms for disseminating information.
- Information, education, and communication material in multiple languages for catering to the migrant and nonmigrant populations along with posters mentioning **frequently asked questions** could be published.
- **Quarterly training sessions** could enhance dealer awareness about the scheme.

## Technological Infrastructure

- Periodic assessment of server capacities and regular server maintenance could help manage the increasing load of transactions.
- Introduction of ration card-based one-time password can provide an additional level of security, and serve as an alternative authentication mechanism.
- Mera Ration app should have additional questions that improve the understanding of user issues and include a grievance redress mechanism.
- Integrated business intelligence systems linked with the FPS digitization module could create an integrated management information system, to support the development of a state-wise performance dashboard, data analytics, and grievance redress and feedback monitoring platform.

## Supply Chain Management

- Dealer awareness regarding the provision in the ONORC for **procuring food grains in advance** (to compensate for potential shortfall) should be raised to avoid procurement through informal systems.
- **Buffer stock may be allocated** to FPSs to ensure continuous supplies.
- Policy review to enable **inclusion of pulses and other food grains** available in the domicile state of the migrants could help beneficiaries maintain nutritional balance.
- Synchronization of the **distribution cycles** of all states and union territories can ensure that beneficiaries are able to buy rations on all working days of a month.
- A system developed to keep the **beneficiaries informed** in case of a delays or shortages via WhatsApp, text message, or call could be helpful in managing demand–supply balance.

## Improving Access for Women

- **Targeted awareness campaigns** and training sessions for women beneficiaries, covering all key aspects of the scheme should be taken up.
- **Training for women FPS license holders** should also be organized to increase their involvement in the supply chain.
- Periodic **social audits** should review challenges faced by women beneficiaries and FPS dealers in the scheme.

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